

Half Marathon Training Plan

24-Week Beginner Program

Race Distance: 21.1 kilometers (13.1 miles)

Target Audience: Runners with 5K experience or basic running fitness

Prerequisites: Able to run 5K continuously or have completed 5K training program

Weekly Training: 4-5 days per week | 4-6 hours total

Program Structure: 6 phases with extended base building and gradual progression

Program Overview

This 24-week extended program takes runners from 5K fitness to half marathon ready with ample time for adaptation. The plan features extended base building, progressive long runs, tempo runs, and speed work. By race day, you'll have completed multiple 20K+ long runs and be confident crossing the finish line.

Key Principles:

- Extended base building phase for injury prevention
 - Progressive long run increases (no more than 10% per week)
 - One speed/tempo session per week for race pace development
 - Strategic taper in final weeks
 - Flexibility to adjust based on individual response
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PHASE 1: FOUNDATION (Weeks 1-6)

Week 1-2: Introduction to Half Marathon Training

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (45 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 40 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2.5 hours

Week 3-4: Build Easy Runs

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 30 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Run (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 30 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (50 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 45 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~3 hours

Week 5-6: Introduce Tempo Work

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 30 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Tempo Run (40 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk + 5 min easy jog
- Main Set: 20 min at tempo pace (comfortably hard)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy jog + 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (55 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk

- Main Set: 50 min easy running (approximately 8K distance)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~3.5 hours

PHASE 2: BUILDING ENDURANCE (Weeks 7-12)

Week 7-8: Extend Tempo Work

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 30 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Tempo Run (45 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk + 5 min easy jog
- Main Set: 25 min at tempo pace
- Cool-down: 5 min easy jog + 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (60 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 55 min easy running (approximately 9K distance)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~3.5 hours

Week 9-10: Build Long Run

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 30 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Tempo Run (45 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk + 5 min easy jog
- Main Set: 25 min at tempo pace
- Cool-down: 5 min easy jog + 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (65 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 60 min easy running (approximately 10K distance)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~4 hours

Week 11-12: Recovery Phase

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min easy running

- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (55 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 50 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~3 hours

PHASE 3: INTRODUCING SPEED (Weeks 13-18)

Week 13-14: Speed Work Introduction

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 30 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Speed Work (40 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk + 5 min easy jog
- Main Set: 6 x 800m at race pace with 2 min recovery jog between

- Cool-down: 5 min easy jog + 5 min easy walk

Thursday: Rest day

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (70 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 65 min easy running (approximately 11K distance)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~4 hours

Week 15-16: Build Speed Work

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 30 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Speed Work (45 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk + 5 min easy jog
- Main Set: 8 x 800m at race pace with 2 min recovery jog
- Cool-down: 5 min easy jog + 5 min easy walk

Thursday: Rest day

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (75 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 70 min easy running (approximately 11.5K distance)

- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~4.5 hours

Week 17-18: Extend Long Run

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 30 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Speed Work (45 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk + 5 min easy jog
- Main Set: 10 x 800m at race pace with 2 min recovery jog
- Cool-down: 5 min easy jog + 5 min easy walk

Thursday: Rest day

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (80 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 75 min easy running (approximately 12.5K distance)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~4.5 hours

PHASE 4: RACE SIMULATION (Weeks 19-21)

Week 19: Peak Long Run

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 30 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Tempo Run (45 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk + 5 min easy jog
- Main Set: 30 min at tempo pace
- Cool-down: 5 min easy jog + 5 min easy walk

Thursday: Rest day

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (90 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 80 min easy running (approximately 13.5K distance - over half marathon distance!)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~4.5 hours

Week 20: Maximum Long Run

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 30 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Tempo Run (45 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk + 5 min easy jog
- Main Set: 30 min at tempo pace
- Cool-down: 5 min easy jog + 5 min easy walk

Thursday: Rest day

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (100 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 90 min easy running (approximately 15K distance - well over half marathon distance!)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~4.5 hours

Week 21: Sustained Effort

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 30 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Tempo Run (45 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk + 5 min easy jog
- Main Set: 30 min at tempo pace

- Cool-down: 5 min easy jog + 5 min easy walk

Thursday: Rest day

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (90 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 80 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~4.5 hours

PHASE 5: FINAL PREPARATION (Weeks 22-23)

Week 22: Begin Taper

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Tempo Run (40 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk + 5 min easy jog
- Main Set: 25 min at tempo pace
- Cool-down: 5 min easy jog + 5 min easy walk

Thursday: Rest day

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (70 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 65 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~3.5 hours

Week 23: Taper Continues

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (25 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 20 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Easy Run (25 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 20 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Thursday: Rest day

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~1.5 hours

PHASE 6: RACE WEEK (Week 24)

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (15 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 10 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Run (10 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 5 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Rest day - Final preparations

- Lay out all gear
- Review race course and elevation profile
- Early bed time

Sunday: RACE DAY!

- Arrive 45 min early
- Warm up gently with 10 min walk + 10 min easy jog
- Trust your 24 weeks of training
- Have fun and enjoy the experience!

Weekly Volume: ~0.5 hours

Running Pacing Guidelines

Easy Pace: You should be able to hold a conversation comfortably. This is your primary training pace.

Tempo Pace: Comfortably hard. You can speak a few words but not full sentences. Approximately 25-30 seconds per mile slower than race pace.

Race Pace: The pace you plan to run the half marathon. You can speak in short sentences but not full conversations.

Speed Work Pace: 800m repeats should be at approximately 5K race pace or slightly faster.

Nutrition for Half Marathon Training

Pre-Run (1-2 hours before):

- Banana with almond butter
- Toast with jam
- Rice cakes with honey
- Small bowl of oatmeal

During Run (sessions >60 min):

- Water with electrolytes every 15-20 min
- Sports drink or energy gels every 30-45 min
- Aim for 30-60g carbs per hour

Post-Run (within 30 min):

- Protein + carbs (chicken with rice, protein smoothie, turkey sandwich)
 - Rehydrate with water or electrolyte drink
 - Aim for 3:1 carb to protein ratio
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Injury Prevention

Warm-up: Always start with 5 minutes of easy walking before running.

Cool-down: Always end with 5 minutes of easy walking after running.

Stretching: Stretch for 15-20 minutes after each run, focusing on calves, hamstrings, quads, hip flexors, and IT band.

Cross-Training: Consider one day of cross-training (cycling, swimming, strength training) per week for injury prevention.

Rest Days: Take at least 2-3 complete rest days per week. Your body adapts during rest, not during training.

Listen to Your Body: If you experience sharp pain (not just muscle soreness), take an extra rest day or consult a healthcare provider.

Race Week Checklist

- ☐ Lay out all gear the night before
 - ☐ Check weather forecast
 - ☐ Review race course map and elevation profile
 - ☐ Plan parking and arrival time
 - ☐ Practice race-day breakfast
 - ☐ Get good sleep 2-3 nights before
 - ☐ Reduce training volume by 80%
 - ☐ Eat familiar foods only
 - ☐ Hydrate consistently
 - ☐ Arrive 45 minutes early on race day
 - ☐ Plan fueling strategy during race
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Remember: This is YOUR training plan. Adjust rest days as needed to fit your life. Consistency beats perfection. You've got this! 🏃